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Score My Side Hustle Idea

Will this side hustle fit around your job?

A scorecard for people who are keeping their job and starting a side hustle.

About 15 minutes.
Bring a pencil.

How this works.

Grab a pencil. This takes about 15 minutes. For every question, fill in the circle that fits best.

1 **Shrink it.** Write the smallest version of your idea.

2 **Check the hard stops.** Five yes or no questions. Any yes means pause and think.

3 **Score the five tests.** Three questions each, scored 0, 1, or 2.

4 **Read your verdict.** It comes from your weakest test.

5 **Run the one-page test.** On your weakest spot, this week.

Score only what you can show.
A name, a number, a link, a date. If you can't show it, it's a 0. A 0 isn't failure. It tells you what to find out.

The weakest test decides.
An idea breaks at its weakest point, so we don't average.

Score the smallest version, not the dream.
The same idea can be a great side hustle at one size and a second job at another.

This is guidance, not a rulebook.
You know your situation better than any scorecard does. If you go against a stop or a verdict, that can be a fine call. Write down why, and what would prove you wrong.

From my misses. I once ran a pool cleaning service. A handful of clients before work, after work, and on weekends would have been a great side hustle. It got too big, too fast. The week stopped belonging to the job.

From my wins. I've started things that cost more than I'd normally risk, because the demand was already proven, the distribution was in place, and clients were lined up. This scorecard would have flagged the cost. The evidence is why I went ahead.

Step 1

Shrink it.

Write the smallest version of this idea you could run on weekends. Everything that follows is scored against this version.

Idea name _____

I will
what you do _____

for
who pays you _____

so they
what they get _____

on
which days _____

Starting with no more than _____ **customers**

Example
I will clean pools for neighbors within 10 minutes of my house, on Saturday mornings, starting with no more than 5 customers.

What does the smallest version need?

Tick everything that applies. Fewer is better.

- [ ] Hiring or managing other people
- [ ] Equipment or tools you would have to buy
- [ ] A space to rent or store things
- [ ] A business entity, separate bank account, or tax setup
- [ ] A license, permit, or insurance
- [ ] Inventory or supplies you would have to stock
- [ ] A website, app, or store you would have to build
- [ ] Fixed appointments or deadlines you cannot move

Ticked: _____

0 to 2 is a light start. 3 to 4 is getting heavy, so can you drop one? 5 or more, shrink it again before you score it.

Step 2

Five hard stops.

Answer yes or no. Any yes means pause and think it through. Usually that means fix it first, then come back. A hard stop is a "not yet," not a "no forever."

	Hard stop	Yes	No
1	**Your work agreement.** Might your employment agreement or an outside-work policy rule this out, or have you not checked yet? Look for outside work, conflicts of interest, and who owns what you create. This is a planning tool, not legal advice.	☐	☐
2	**Reachable 9 to 5.** Does it need you reachable on weekdays during work hours? Calls, live support, same-day replies, showing up in person.	☐	☐
3	**Hard-to-get requirements.** Does it need a license, insurance, or equipment that is costly or hard to get? Basic tools you already own don't count.	☐	☐
4	**Your 2 a.m. number.** The most you could lose without touching your family's cushion: $ _____ Could finding out if this works cost more than that, after subtracting money customers have already committed (deposits, signed clients, paid orders)?	☐	☐
5	**Home.** Does anyone who would feel the hours or the dollars not know yet, or not agree?	☐	☐

Going ahead anyway?

Strong evidence can justify a bigger bet. Real buyers, a real door, and clients lined up (Tests 1 and 2) make a stop 3 or 4 yes much less scary. Thin evidence doesn't.

Which stop _____ **Why I'm going ahead** _____

What would prove me wrong _____

From my misses. The licenses, insurance, and equipment piled up on my pool business. I could have gotten past it by staying lean. I got over my skis instead.

Test 1

Already has buyers

Pick a market that already pays.

Test total ☐ / 6

1a. Have you seen strangers actually pay for something like this?

0. No. I think people would want it, or only friends and family say they would.
1. I've seen it sold, but couldn't tell how often.
2. Yes, and I can show it. At least 3 recent sales or dated reviews from strangers.

1b. Have you asked a stranger for money?

0. Never asked.
1. I've asked friends or family.
2. I've asked strangers. Even if they said no, I know why.

1c. Why would a stranger pick you over what's already there?

0. I'd be about the same as everyone else.
1. I'd be cheaper or more convenient, but anyone could match that.
2. I can name one specific thing that's different and hard to copy, in one sentence.

> **From my misses.** I started a fitness company in a crowded space with nothing that set me apart. I couldn't get people to pay. If you'd be competing with people who have far more money, information, or time than you (trading is one), your 1c is probably a 0.

Test 2

Already has a door

Sell where buyers already are.

Test total ☐ / 6

2a. Is there a place buyers already go to find this? A marketplace, search, local groups, a platform.

0. I'd have to build an audience or a website first.
1. Maybe. I know a place but haven't tried it.
2. Yes. I can name the place and I've seen buyers asking or buying there.

2b. Could you get your first 10 customers with zero followers?

0. Not without ads, an audience, or luck.
1. Probably, but I'd have to learn a new channel first.
2. Yes. I can describe the steps in 5 lines or fewer.

2c. If that door closed, would you have another?

0. No. The whole thing runs through one platform or one person.
1. I could find another, but it would take months.
2. Yes. I already have a second way in, or it doesn't depend on one platform.

> **From my misses.** With the fitness company I was starting from the ground up, trying to get people to a website. There was no door already open.

Test 3

Fits your week

The week belongs to the job.

Test total ☐ / 6

3a. Do the hours fit?

Honest hours I can protect each week: _____ Hours my smallest version needs: _____

(0) It needs more than I have, or I'm not sure.
(1) It needs about what I have, with no slack.
(2) It needs no more than two thirds of what I have.

3b. If you skipped a week (sick kid, big deadline), what happens?

(0) Customers leave or things pile up.
(1) Some pain, but it recovers.
(2) Nothing breaks.

3c. What if it works too well? If it doubled next month, what happens?

(0) I couldn't keep up and I'd have no way to say no.
(1) I'd manage for a while but I have no plan.
(2) I can cap it. A waitlist, a customer limit, or a price that slows demand.

> **From my misses.** My pool business worked, then got too big too quick and collided with my job. I also ran a home wholesaling business. It needed a bigger operation and more of my attention than I had. Check what you ticked in Step 1.

Test 4

Safe to be wrong

Your 2 a.m. number: $ _____

Test total ☐ / 6

4a. What would it cost to find out if this works? Include the one-page test and the first month, minus money customers already committed.

(0) More than my 2 a.m. number, or I don't know.
(1) Within it, but I'd feel it.
(2) Less than half of it.

4b. Could you stop in one weekend and owe nothing? No leases, unsellable inventory, contracts, or loans.

(0) No. I'd be locked into something.
(1) Mostly. One or two things to unwind.
(2) Yes. I could stop Sunday night and owe nothing.

4c. Could you watch the swings without losing sleep?

(0) It uses my family's cushion, or I'd check it constantly.
(1) It's my own spare money, but I'd watch it closely.
(2) I'd be fine if it went to zero, and I wouldn't need to check daily.

> **From my misses.** I dabbled in stock trading. The ups and downs were more than I could stomach, it was my family's money, and the people on the other side had far more resources than I did.

Test 5

The math holds

Your napkin. This is your own arithmetic, not a forecast.

Test total ☐ / 6

A	**Aim for, per month**	$ _____
B	**Profit per sale** Price, minus what it costs you to deliver, including fees.	$ _____
C	**Sales needed per month** A ÷ B	_____
D	**Hours per sale** Finding the customer, doing the work, the admin.	_____
E	**Hours needed per month** C × D	_____
F	**Hours you can protect per month** Your weekly hours from 3a × 4	_____

5a. Do the hours fit? Compare E and F.

(0) E is more than F.
(1) E is up to F, with little room.
(2) E is no more than three quarters of F.

5b. Is the profit per sale real?

(0) A guess.
(1) Estimated from similar sellers.
(2) From costs I've actually priced out (materials, fees, delivery, my time).

5c. Does one source carry the plan? One customer, one platform, or one supplier.

(0) One source is more than half.
(1) One source is about half.
(2) No source is more than a third.

One paycheck is a single point of failure. Don't build a second one. The math can tell you whether an idea works on paper. It can't tell you whether it will.

Step 4

Your verdict.

Write each test's score (0 to 6) and draw a dashed line around the lowest one.
Your verdict comes from that one.

Test 1 Buyers	Test 2 Door	Test 3 Week	Test 4 Safe	Test 5 Math	Total out of 30

- [ ] **Go. Start Saturday.**
  Your lowest test is 4 or more
  It passed. Pick a start date and keep the first version small.

- [ ] **Fix one thing first.**
  Your lowest test is 2 or 3
  One weak spot. Change it, then rescore that test.

- [ ] **Prove it before you spend.**
  Your lowest test is 0 or 1
  Run the one-page test on that test before you put in money or weekends.

- [ ] **Not this one. Next idea.**
  Two or more tests at 0 or 1
  Better to know on day one than in month six.

Any hard stop with a yes? Fix that first, or write down why you're going ahead anyway. The verdict doesn't count until you've dealt with the stops.

A verdict is a recommendation, not a ruling. If your gut and the scorecard disagree, don't ignore either one. Find out why. Then decide.

Step 5

The one-page test.

Run only the one for your weakest test. If two are tied, start with the lower number. Keep it under $25 and one week. Then rescore that test.

Weakest test	This week, do this	Pass if
1. Buyers	Write a one-line offer with a price. Put it where buyers already look, or message 10 people who recently bought something similar. Ask 5 for a real commitment, such as a booked time or a pre-order.	At least 2 say yes with a date or money, or you learn exactly why not.
2. Door	Post one real offer on the place buyers already go. Count messages for 7 days, not likes.	At least 3 real inquiries from strangers.
3. Week	Run a mock Saturday. Do one customer-sized job in the real time slot you'd use. Time every step, including admin. Note what interrupts you.	It took no more than the hours you budgeted, and the rest of your week didn't suffer.
4. Safe	Write your 2 a.m. number. Spend 15 minutes with the person at home: the idea, the hours, the most you'll risk, and what would make them uneasy. List every contract, lease, or purchase and check that each can be undone.	You both agree on the number, and nothing on your list can't be undone.
5. Math	Replace one guess with a real number. Get one real price (a quote or a competitor's published price) and one real cost. Redo the napkin.	The hours needed fit within the hours you have, using real numbers.

The test I'm running _____ **Start** _____ **Done by** _____

What counts as a pass _____

After the week, rescore that test. If it's now 4 or more, check your next-lowest test.

Optional

Comparing ideas.

Most people have two or three ideas. Score each one on its own copy of the scorecard, then fill this in. The lowest test decides. The total only breaks a tie.

	Idea A	Idea B	Idea C
Idea name			
Hard stops clear?			
Test 1: Buyers			
Test 2: Door			
Test 3: Week			
Test 4: Safe			
Test 5: Math			
Lowest test			
Total out of 30			
Verdict			

Keep your job. Start a side hustle.

Score My Side Hustle Idea is a planning tool, not financial, legal, or tax advice, and nothing here is a promise of income. Made by Gabe De Almeida. Follow along at @itsgabedealmeida.